

Cuprite

△ **Cuprite rough**, an uncommon copper mineral

The mineral **cuprite** is named from the Latin *cuprum*, meaning “copper”, and it is sometimes known as ruby copper due to its distinctive carmine-red colour. Almost every faceted stone larger than one carat has come from a single deposit in Namibia, which is now exhausted – and even these are rare. Faceted stones are too soft to wear, but their brilliance and garnet-red colour is exceptional, making them highly desirable as collector’s stones. Other localities that produce lesser amounts of smaller gem material are Australia, Bolivia, and Chile.

Specification

Chemical name	Copper oxide	Formula	Cu ₂ O	Colours
Shades of red to nearly black		Structure	Cubic	Hardness
3.5–4	SG 6.1	RI 2.85	Lustre	Adamantine, submetallic
Streak	Brownish red	Locations	Namibia originally; now also Australia, Bolivia, Chile	



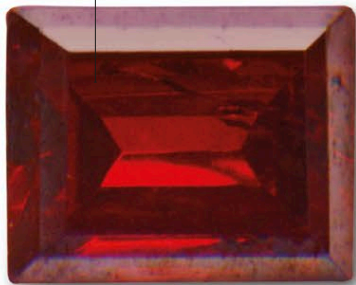
Tiny crystals

Small cuprite crystals | Rough | This group of tiny cuprite crystals provides much gem-quality material – the faces shine with adamantine lustre.



Good-quality crystal face

Gem-quality crystals | Rough | These crisply formed cuprite crystals have good transparency, and each would cut a small, but fine, gem.



Flawless stone

Rectangular step | Cut | The superb clarity of this rare cuprite gem is emphasized by using a shallow step cut. It has intense colour and a shiny lustre.



Slightly cloudy surface

Oval brilliant | Cut | This cuprite gem has developed a slight metallic sheen on its surface, most likely as the result of a reaction with light over time.



Scattered cuprite crystals

Common cuprite | Rough | This cuprite specimen has a large number of minute crystals, and exhibits a rare form of fibrous cuprite, chalcotrichite.